

Ῥωμανὸς ὁ Μελωδός

Romanos the Melodist and the Byzantine Hymn

eul_aid: uyq

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)
Dialect: Κοινή Χριστιανική [Christian Koine](#)
Domain: Ποίησις [Poetry](#)
Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)

Romanos the Melodist was a major Byzantine poet and hymn writer of the sixth century CE. He is traditionally believed to have been from Emesa in Syria and served as a deacon, first in Beirut and later in Constantinople at churches such as Hagia Sophia. According to later legendary accounts, his poetic talent was miraculously granted by the Virgin Mary.

He specialized in composing kontakia, which were verse sermons or hymns intended for church liturgy. Approximately 60 hymns are securely attributed to him, with manuscripts preserving around 90 under his name. Among his most celebrated works are kontakia for major feasts like the Nativity, the Presentation of Christ, Good Friday, and Easter.

Romanos is considered the most important master of the kontakion form. According to modern scholars, he developed this genre from earlier Syriac models into a sophisticated Greek art form that combined biblical storytelling, theology, and dramatic dialogue. His hymns were central to worship in Constantinople for centuries and significantly influenced later Byzantine religious poetry and popular devotion, even after the kontakion itself declined in use.

Works (4)

- Ἀκάθιστος ὕμνος · [Akathist Hymn](#) · 306 passages
- Ἀμφίβολοι Ὡδαί · [Dubious Songs](#) · 595 passages
- Γνήσιαι Ὡδαί · [Genuine Songs](#) · 1282 passages
- Ὡδαί · [Songs](#) · 1512 passages